What is a habitat?

BACKGROUND

species (say 'spee-seas') – a group of living things that can breed together to produce fertile offspring

The particular place where a **population** of a living thing lives is called its **habitat**. A population is a group of animals from the same species that lives in the same space, such as a population of gorillas in a mountain range. A habitat can be as big as a rainforest or as small as a burrow, depending on how much space the population needs.

Many living things need to be able to find food, water, clean air, shelter, warmth, light and safety in their environment. When one or more of these basic needs is no longer available – for example, if drinking water is no longer available in drier months – the population may sometimes move to a new habitat.

☞ **1** How do each of these living things meet some of their needs? Complete the table by writing these phrases into the correct spaces.

fresh grass to graze on	eucalyptus leaves	fruit trees
sharp claws and teeth	coral reef	a protective family group
underground burrows	protection of a sea anemone	

Living thing	Food	Shelter	Safety from predators
rabbit			burrows with hidden entrances
clownfish	tiny fish, plankton		
spider monkey		leafy beds in the high rainforest canopy	
koala		tall trees high off the ground	

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What is a habitat? CONT'D

2 Use the code to find the things that most living things need from their environment.

Code

a	b	c	d	e	f	g	h	i	j	k	l	m
8	1	15	11	17	26	2	10	19	20	3	12	21
n	**o**	**p**	**q**	**r**	**s**	**t**	**u**	**v**	**w**	**x**	**y**	**z**
4	25	13	16	9	7	22	18	6	24	23	14	5

a) __ __ __ __ __ __ __

7 10 17 12 22 17 9

b) __ __ __ __

26 25 25 11

c) __ __ __ __ __ __ __ __

15 12 17 8 4 8 19 9

d) __ __ __ __ __

24 8 22 17 9

3 Use the information in the table in Question 1 to describe the habitat for each of the following animals. Use your general knowledge to add more information.

a) rabbit habitat

b) clownfish habitat

c) koala habitat

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